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5G Gaming, metaverse use will grow in India

With a large youth population and more 5G penetration, India's cloud gaming ecosystem will grow rapidly, says Ericsson India's MD

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With PM Modi officially launching 5G in India in October 2022, Indian consumers seem all set to elevate their digital experience through 2023 and beyond. Even yours truly is eagerly awaiting for their network provider to start 5G services in their vicinity!

With 5G already live in many cities in India, and pan-India 5G coverage only set to grow in the near future, we spoke to Nitin Bansal, MD, Ericsson India and

Head of Network Solutions, Southeast Asia, Oceania & India at Ericsson to understand how 5G deployment in India is going to empower users with new mobile experiences and increase the potential for new innovative applications. We spoke on a range of topics, with Mr Bansal providing insights on how 5G deployment in India is uniquely indigenous, how cloud gaming especially is going to increase by leaps and bounds in the country (thanks in no small part to the 5G networks), and what

will happen to older 2G and 3G networks in the near future as 5G usage ramps up. Edited excerpts follow:

Q How is 5G rollout in India tied to the 'Make in India' initiative? Any stats or figures to share?

A The 5G rollout and 'Make in India' initiative are complementary to each other. By enabling industry 4.0, 5G will strengthen industrial capabilities of Indian businesses by making machines smarter, factories more efficient, and manufacturing processes faster. The 'Make in India' initiative augmented by PLI schemes set the stage for 5G deployment by delivering indigenous telecom equipment and creating a robust domestic value chain within the country. It is worth highlighting that in 1994 Ericsson became the first telecom equipment company to start its manufacturing in India.

Indian communication service providers or CSPs are rapidly building a robust 5G infrastructure for their 5G deployments. As per the latest Ericsson Mobility Report, 5G subscriptions will reach around 690 million by the end of 2028. Further, 5G will represent around 53 per cent of mobile subscriptions at the end of 2028.

Q How is the Indian telecom sector going to evolve on the back of 5G over the next few years?

A Enhanced mobile broadband (eMBB) and fixed wireless access (FWA) are expected to be the early use-cases of 5G in India. These will help address the concern of the limited fixed broadband penetration levels in India and improve the data experience while on the move. According to the Ericsson Mobility Report, FWA is forecast to grow at 19 per cent year-on-year through 2022-28, and top 300 million connections by the end of 2028.

Over time with 5G, we expect more enterprise-related use cases to come up in sectors like manufacturing, health-care, education, etc. In fact, as per Ericsson's report - 5G for business: a 2030 market compass study – the projected value of the 5G-enabled digitalisation